21077 – THE EMERGENCE OF ENTREPRENEURIAL VENTURES: THEORY AND PRACTICE

COURSE SYLLABUS A.Y. 2026-2027

Class 27

Instructors: Profs Cédric Gutierrez (cedric.gutierrez@unibocconi.it) and Nico Valenti Gatto (nico.valentigatto@unibocconi.it)

Dates	Hours	Room
September 7 – November 23	13.45-16.15 (Mon)	N37
	10:15-12:45 (Wed)	N39

For the exact schedule, please see "Schedule / Course Content."
For all teaching material, please see: http://blackboard.unibocconi.it.

Course objectives

Entrepreneurship is one of the major drivers of economic growth, technological innovation, and social transformation. This foundational course offers a rigorous, research-based understanding of entrepreneurship. It addresses a set of core questions: who becomes an entrepreneur, and why; how entrepreneurs exercise judgment under uncertainty; how ideas become opportunities; what strategic choices shape the trajectory of ventures; and how ventures attract customers, raise resources, grow, and exit.

The course deliberately combines theory and practice. Each session reviews the main theoretical traditions and the most relevant recent empirical evidence on a given aspect of entrepreneurship and applies them to the discussion of real entrepreneurial cases.

As the first entrepreneurship course of the INTENT master, its goal is not to teach you how to write a detailed business plan but to give you the conceptual foundations and the evidence-based posture you will need to interrogate entrepreneurial decisions throughout the program and your career.

By the end of the course, you will be able to:

- explain who becomes a successful entrepreneur, and why;
- compare frameworks for entrepreneurial action under uncertainty;
- define entrepreneurial opportunities and explain their drivers and the role of the individual–opportunity nexus;
- explain the role of entrepreneurial hypotheses and their testing;
- compare different types of entrepreneurial strategy;
- describe the key elements of a business model and explain how ventures create and capture value;
- analyze the dynamics of founding teams, including trade-offs in co-founder choice, role allocation, and equity;
- identify the main sources and stages of entrepreneurial finance and assess their implications for control and growth;
- identify the drivers, paths, and challenges of venture growth.

Course format and style

The course leverages a blend of methods aimed at complementing each other and optimizing the learning experience:

- **Lectures** review the main theoretical traditions and the most relevant recent empirical evidence for each topic and use them to test common intuitions about entrepreneurship.
- **Case discussions** complement the lectures: most sessions discuss a real entrepreneurial situation that students analyze.
- **Guest-speaker talks** expose students to the lived experience of accomplished entrepreneurs and investors, treated as “living cases” that students interrogate with the frameworks learnt in class.
- **A collaborative team assignment** lets students put the course’s frameworks into practice by evaluating a real start-up on the main dimensions covered in the course.

Course materials

All course materials will be distributed through Blackboard. The list of readings is provided at the beginning of the course and is available to all students, including non-attending students; copyright-protected readings can be accessed through the University Library’s reserve service. Slides and any additional materials used in class are made available to all students through Blackboard.

There is no single required textbook; a useful companion for several sessions is J. Gans, E. Scott & S. Stern, Entrepreneurship: Choice and Strategy (W. W. Norton, 2024).

Schedule / Course Content

The instructors reserve the right to change readings and schedule at any time during the course. The order of classes may also be subject to changes.

N	Date	Time	Contents	Support material	Instructor
1	07-Sep	13.45-16.15	Introduction. The returns to entrepreneurship.		GUTIERREZ
2	09-Sep	10.15-12.45	Entrepreneurial judgment and action: deciding under uncertainty.		GUTIERREZ
3	14-Sep	13.45-16.15	Entrepreneurial opportunities.	Case study: Embrace	GUTIERREZ
4	16-Sep	10.15-12.45	Entrepreneurial strategy.		GUTIERREZ
5	21-Sep	13.45-16.15	Customers and business models.	Case study: Rent the Runway	GUTIERREZ
6	23-Sept	10.15-12.45	From problem to business model.		VALENTI
7	28-Sept	13.45-16.15	Founding teams.	Case study: Ockham	GUTIERREZ
8	30-Sept	10.15-12.45	Co-founders & founder prenups.		VALENTI
9	05-Oct	13.45-16.15	Financing entrepreneurial ventures.	Case study: Jibo	GUTIERREZ
10	07-Oct	10.15-12.45	Scaling and exit.	Case study: Baroo	GUTIERREZ
11	12-Oct	13.45-16.15	The industry and the mindset.		VALENTI
12	28-Oct	10:15-12:45	Building before you raise.		VALENTI
13	04-Nov	10.15-12.45			COLAO
14	11-Nov	10.15-12.45			COLAO
15	18-Nov	10.15-12.45	The geography of entrepreneurship.		GUTIERREZ
16	23-Nov	13.45-16.15	Social entrepreneurship & wrap up.	Case study: Sababa	GUTIERREZ

Grading

The assessment combines an individual written exam with a collaborative team assignment. Your final grade is determined as follows:

A. Individual written exam	**60%**
B. Group project	**40%**
C. Class participation	**up to 1 bonus point**

Points earned for each component are weighted and summed to obtain a total score for the course. An overview of each component follows.

A. Individual written exam (60%)

The final exam will include a mix of open- and close-ended questions covering the main concepts discussed in class, for a total of 30 points. Sample questions will be discussed in class and posted on Blackboard.

B. Group project (40%)

In self-formed teams, you evaluate a real start-up on the main dimensions covered in the course (e.g., opportunity, business model, strategy, founding team, financing, and growth). The assignment tests your ability to apply the theoretical perspectives learnt in the course to real ventures, to critically evaluate entrepreneurial ideas, business models, and strategic choices, and to communicate structured analytical reasoning. The output is a written memo.

C. Class participation (up to 1 bonus point)

Class discussion is a central part of the learning experience, and you can earn one bonus point for consistent and high-quality participation.

Non-attending students

Non-attending students are evaluated solely on an individual written exam, consisting of open and/or closed questions on the main concepts of the course (slides, cases, and readings), for a total of 30 points.

Course office

Department of Management and Technology — Via Röntgen 1, 4th floor.
Students should contact the course office only for scheduling and registration problems, through the Help&Contact procedure in you@B. Please notify the instructors as well.

Your instructors

Cédric Gutierrez is Professor of Strategic Management at Bocconi University, which he joined in September 2017. He received his PhD in Strategy from HEC Paris.

Nico Valenti Gatto is the Chief Executive Officer at Tech Europe Foundation Fund.

Office hours

Both professors will hold office hours by appointment during the semester.
Please send an email to “book” a slot during the office hours along with the focus of the meeting. Office hours can be attended in groups or individually.

Norms of behavior

To have a productive class, we kindly ask you to respect the following:

- Please limit the use of hand-held devices during class. This policy is based on research documenting their effect on you and on your classmates.
- Communicating with the instructors: please do not send the same request to each of us separately. Choose the one whose class it relates to, or cc all of us.
- Class representative — please use your class rep to share points of concern, confusion, and satisfaction; we find it helpful when they gather feedback from the class.
- Re-grading policy: for any re-grading request, we expect a written memo explaining why the work earned a higher score. If we agree there is cause for re-grading, we will re-grade the whole work, which may change the grades of other parts as well.

Università Bocconi conceives of education as an ongoing process that stretches across a person's entire professional life and asks the whole community to respect the values of fairness and correctness that inspire its shared mission. We encourage all students to read the Bocconi University Honor Code, published at http://www.unibocconi.eu/honorcode.